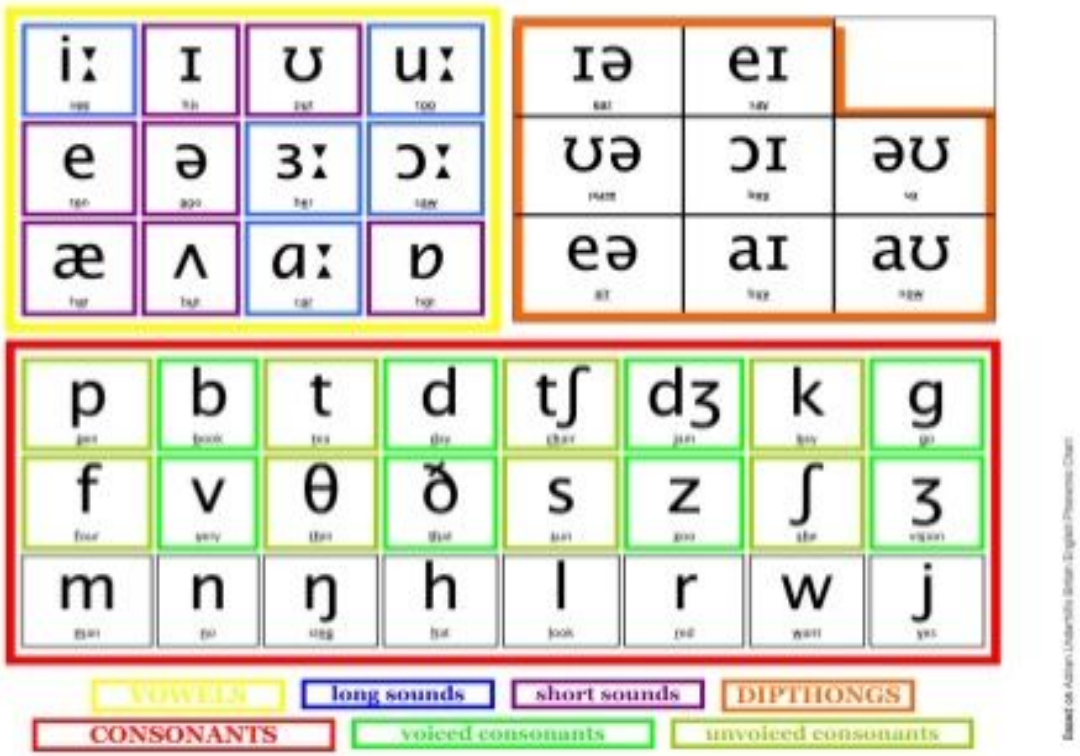
BASIC ENGLISH PHONETICS



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Phonetics

The English alphabet has **26 letters** but the possibilities of pronunciation are much higher **(actually 44!!)**

We use the **IPA** (***International Phonetic Alphabet***) **symbols.** Some may look strange at first but with a bit of practice it is easy as pie. We use / / or [ ] to indicate the phonetic representation.

a b c d e f g

h i j k l m n

o p q r s t u

v w x y z

The Phonetic Alphabet

- Dialectal and individual differences affect pronunciation, but the sounds of English

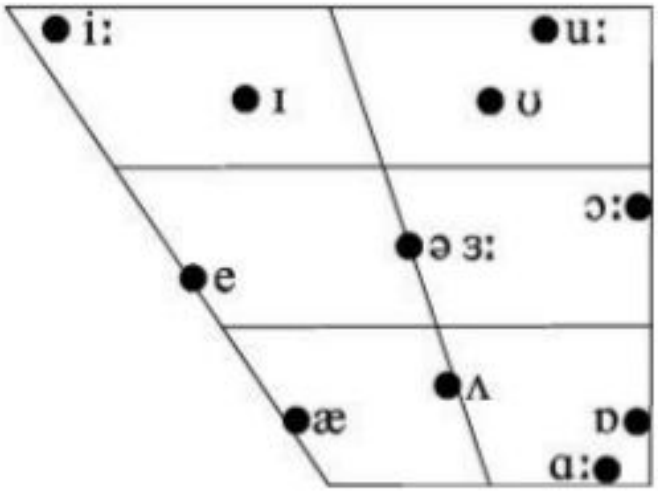
TABLE 6.1 | A Phonetic Alphabet for English Pronunciation

Consonants						Vowels			
p	**p**ill	t	**t**ill	k	**k**ill	i	b**ee**t	ɪ	b**i**t
b	**b**ill	d	**d**ill	g	**g**ill	e	b**ai**t	ɛ	b**e**t
m	**m**ill	n	**n**il	ŋ	ri**ng**	u	b**oo**t	ʊ	f**oo**t
f	**f**eel	s	**s**eal	h	**h**eal	o	b**oa**t	ɔ	b**o**re
v	**v**eal	z	**z**eal	l	**l**eaf	æ	b**a**t	a	p**o**t/b**a**r
θ	**th**igh	tʃ	**ch**ill	r	**r**eef	ʌ	b**u**tt	ə	sof**a**
ð	**th**y	dʒ	**g**in	j	**y**ou	aɪ	b**i**te	aʊ	b**ou**t
ʃ	**sh**ill	ʍ	**wh**ich	w	**w**itch	ɔɪ	b**oy**		
ʒ	mea**s**ure								

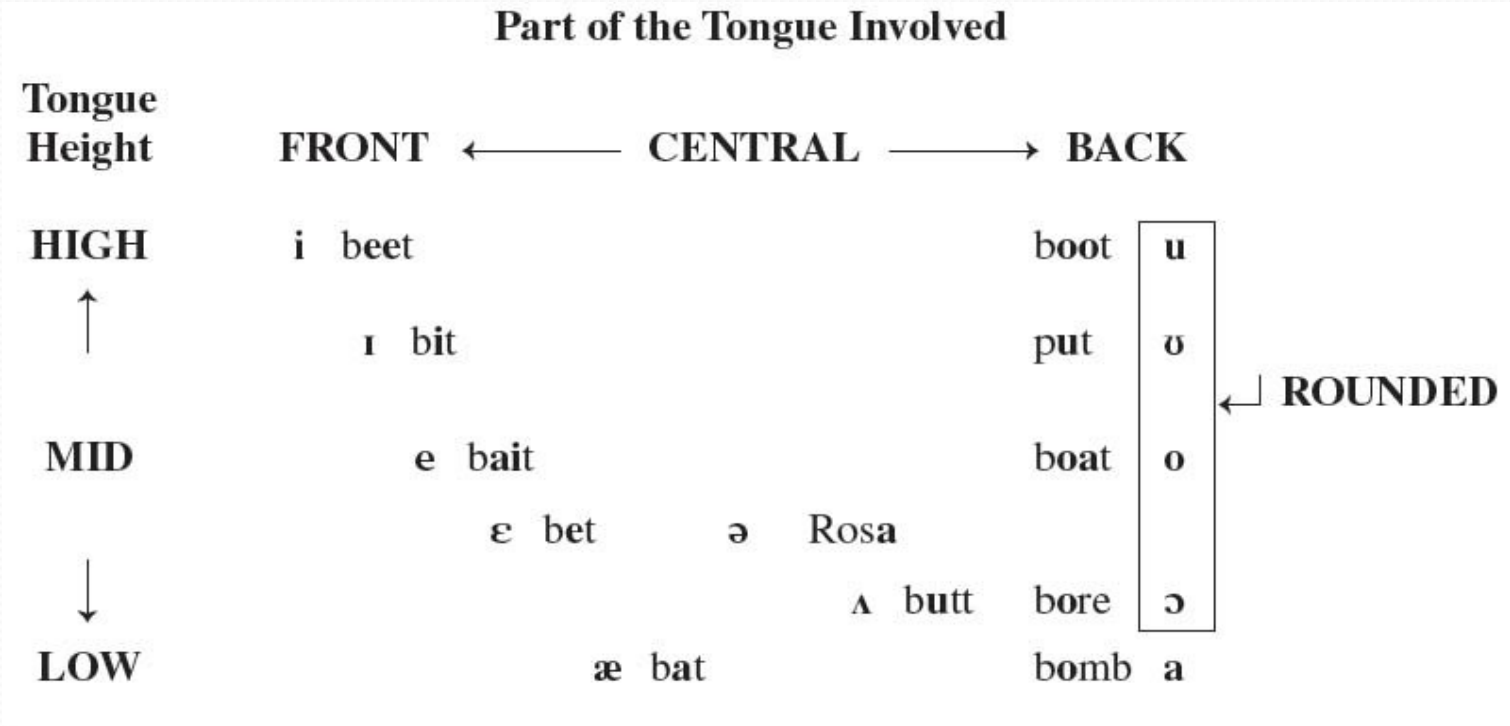
Vowels

We have **5 vowels** but **12** different pronunciation possibilities in **BrE** (British English) and **10 in AmE** (American English).

English vowels can be **short** or **long** *(:)*



Front- Central – Back Vowels



Vowels

/ɪ/ as in *s**i**t, ver**y**, pr**e**tty, lad**ie**s, vill**a**ge...*

/iː/ as in *m**ee**t, b**e**, kn**ea**d, f**ie**ld, s**ei**ze, k**ey**, pol**i**ce...*

/e/ as in *b**e**d, h**ea**d, m**a**ny...*

/ɜː/ as in *b**ir**d, h**er**, h**ear**d, t**ur**n, w**or**d...*

/æ/ as in *h**a**nd, f**ai**l... (not in AmE)*

/ʌ/ as in *s**u**n, s**o**n, c**ou**ntry, d**oe**s, fl**oo**d...*

/ɑː/ as in *p**a**ss, h**ea**rt, cl**e**rk, h**a**lf, f**ar**m, **au**nt...*

/ɒ/ as in *p**o**t, w**a**s, c**ou**gh, **Au**stria... (not in AmE)*

/ɔː/ as in *h**or**se, c**au**se, d**oor**, b**ou**ght...*

/ʊ/ as in *p**u**t, w**o**lf, c**ou**ld, t**oo**l...*

/uː/ as in *t**oo**, m**o**ve, gr**ou**p, r**u**de, gr**ew**, bl**ue**, sh**oe**...*

/ə/ this is the <u>most frequent pronunciation</u> of any unstressed vowel in English as in ***a**go, moth**e**r, prior**i**ty, cust**o**mer, Port**u**gal...*

Diphthongs

There are **7 or 8 diphthongs** in English depending on the classification we follow:

/eɪ/ as in *b**ay**, h**ey**, f**a**te, j**ai**l, v**ei**l, conv**ey**, gr**ea**t...*

/aɪ/ as in *b**uy**, h**i**gh, sk**y**, h**ei**ght, p**ie**, d**ye**...*

/aʊ/ as in *m**ou**th, h**ow**, br**ow**n...*

/ɔɪ/ as in *b**oy***

/ɪə/ as in *h**ere**, d**eer**, d**ear**, p**ier**ce, w**eir**d, id**ea**, **Ia**n, mus**eu**m, th**eo**ry...*

/eə/ as in *sp**are**, ch**air**, t**ear**, th**ere**...*

/əʊ/ as in *h**o**me, r**oa**d, J**oe**, sl**ow**...*

/ʊə/ as in *p**oor**, s**ure**...*

Dipthongs

Diphthongs

1.	[eɪ]	e.g. day, afraid, great
2.	[ɑɪ]	e.g. July, decide, buy
3.	[ɔɪ]	e.g. boy, voice, enjoy
4.	[əʊ]	e.g. close, know, moment
5.	[ɑʊ]	e.g. town, flower, mountain
6.	[ɪə]	e.g. hear, here, appear
7.	[eə]	e.g. hair, wear, parents
8.	[ʊə]	e.g. sure, January

Semivowels or semiconsonants

They are sounds that share some characteristics with vowels and others with consonants. There are **2** semivowels in English.
Here are they:

/w/ as in *t**w**elve, conq**u**est, lang**u**age...*
/j/ as in ***y**es, **u**niform, **Eu**rope...*

Consonants

Most consonants are divided into **voiced** or **unvoiced** depending on the vibration of vocal cords.

Voiced

/b/ as in ***b**each, we**b**, su**b**way...*

/d/ as in ***D**ani, sa**d**, a**dd**...*

/g/ as in ***g**irl, dra**g**, clo**gg**ed...*

/dʒ/ as in ***j**am, **g**el, **g**in, **j**oy, ed**g**e...*

/v/ as in ***v**ehicle, li**v**e...*

/ð / as in ***th**is, fa**th**er...*

/z/ as in ***z**oo, ro**s**e...*

/ʒ/ as in *vi**s**ion, plea**s**ure, bei**ge**...*

Consonants

Unvoiced

/p/ as in ***p**otato, ta**p**, cla**pp**ing...*

/t/ as in ***t**ea, pe**t**, se**tt**ing ...*

/k/ as in ***c**ar, **k**ey, tre**kk**ing, chi**ck**en, a**cc**urate, **qu**een, thi**ck**, boo**k**, **ch**aos...*

/f/ as in ***f**ast, **ph**one, leaf, sta**ff**, enou**gh**...*

/s/ as in **s**ell, **c**ity, **p**ass...

/θ/ as in ***th**in, tee**th**...*

/ʃ/ as in ***sh**e, **s**ugar, na**ti**on, lea**sh**...*

/tʃ/ as in *charity, na**t**ure, tea**ch**...*

Consonants

Finally there are other consonants to consider:

/m/ as in ***m**an, To**m**, tri**mm**ed...*
/n/ as in ***n**ose, si**n**, ru**nn**ing...*
/ŋ/ as in *ri**n**ger, si**ng**, si**nk**...*
/l/ as in ***l**ate, ta**l**e, ta**ll**, ca**ll**ed...*
/h/ as in ***h**it, a**h**ead...*
/r/ as in ***r**at, ve**r**y, ca**rr**ot...*

Transcribe the following

- Fire- /fair/
- Higher
- Hour
- Layer
- Lair
- Mayor
- Player
- Power
- Royal
- Gate/geit/
- Say-/sei/
- Fine-/fain/

- Rain-/**rein/**
- Kite/kait/
- Fun
- Sun
- May-/mei/
- Care
- Remind
- Coin
- Nine/nain/
- Paint/peint/
- Gain /gein/
- ruin

Questions?

- **neiʃn/** **sit-/<u>sit/</u>**
- Student-/ seat-/**si:t/**
- / e**dʒjukeiʃn/**
- Computer
- Chat
- Internet
- Focus
- Aim
- life